

What is Democratic Erosion, and why is it occurring in Nigeria?



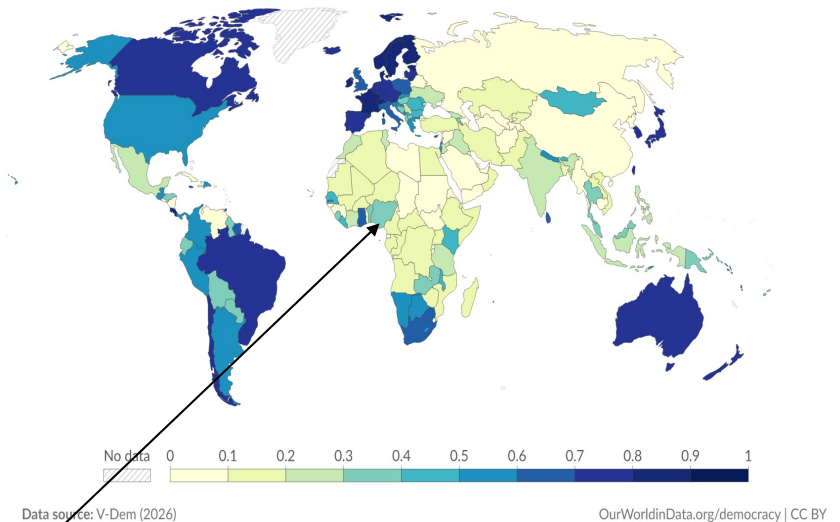
- ▶ "A former Nigerian senator alleged over 90 percent of elections held in the country since independence have been rigged" (Media Talk Africa)
- ▶ Rigging: "illegitimate and undemocratic means of tilting the playing field clearly in the favor of one party or candidate at the expense of others" (Cheeseman and Klaas, *How To Rig An Election*)
- ▶ Incumbents have the power, resources, and connections to retain power and civilians organize bottom-up reform with minimal resources (*How To Steal An Election* Pol S 220 course notes)
- ▶ Restricted communications, a strong deficit of individual rights and lack of personal autonomy make bottom-up reform unrealistic (Freedom House)

Nigeria: LBI is
~0.3 (V-DEM)

Liberal Democracy Index, 2025

Data by V-Dem. Expert estimates of the extent of voting rights, the freedom and fairness of elections, freedoms of association and expression, civil liberties, and executive constraints. The index ranges from 0 to 1 (most democratic).

Our World
in Data



(Our World in Data)

Short-Term Impact of Stolen Elections

- ▶ Discrimination of ethnic minority groups (Freedom House)
- ▶ State-sanctioned crime (Freedom House)
- ▶ State interference in business and market; tight civilian regulations (Freedom House)
- ▶ No equality of opportunity or freedom from economic exploitation (Freedom House)
- ▶ Excessive force to suppress civilian dissent:

"The military has been repeatedly criticized by local and international human rights groups for...abuses...Police were accused of using excessive force against participants in the #EndBadGovernance demonstrations in August and September 2024" (Freedom House)

Live Ammunition on protestors in recent years to suppress dissent (Hasanuddin University)



(International Centre for Investigative Reporting)

Long-Term Consequences of Rigged Elections

- ▶ Loss of (multi-level) legitimacy, and public distrust/resentment (Hasanuddin University)
- ▶ Large-scale financial corruption altering efficacy of formerly reliable institutions (U.S. State Department)
- ▶ Unilateral conflict: civilians unwilling to fight due to distrust/resentment (Freedom House)
- ▶ Worsened discrimination against ethnic/religious minorities (Hasanuddin University)
- ▶ Removal of social freedoms: choice of marriage partner, size of family, protection from domestic violence, and control over appearance (Freedom House)
- ▶ Theoretical idea: Import economy of agriculture collapses
 - ▶ Nigeria produces almost none of its own food (Punch NG)



(The Atlantic)

Theoretical Impacts on Global Politics & Circumstances

- ▶ Economic and energy crisis from loss of income due to crude oil and petroleum exports to the U.S. and U.K. (U.S. Energy Information Administration)
- ▶ Mass exodus of wealthy Nigerians leads to global migrant crisis and hostile social conditions (locally and abroad)
- ▶ Religious sectarian violence, likely propped up by theocratic foreign governments and institutions
- ▶ Leakage of corruption into neighboring countries, leading to a crisis of international law enforcement and souring impressions of the region
- ▶ Foreign investment and intervention in Nigeria forming rigid alliances



(The Guardian)

11 Modern Ways to Protect Elections and Save Democracy

- ▶ Fund election observers
 - Make observers independent
 - Publicize election results in real time
- ▶ Strengthen domestic groups
 - Support digital literacy campaigns
 - Strengthen social media platforms
 - Support fact-checking organizations
- ▶ Judge quality, not the outcome of the election
- ▶ Protect technology from attack
 - Encourage paper voting
- ▶ Lead by example
 - *1-10 *How To Steal An Election* lecture notes
 - *11 Hasanuddin Journal of Strategic and International Studies

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